

FRONT OFFICE · ROSTER · RUMOR MILL

LAS VEGAS RAIDERS

INTEL REPORT

2026 training camp edition — a unique redshirt-Heisman model, Fernando Mendoza learning behind Kirk Cousins, and Klint Kubiak's Super Bowl OC pedigree.

UPDATED

July 25, 2026

Klint Kubiak

NEW HEAD COACH

\$280M+

FREE AGENCY SPEND

Fernando Mendoza

#1 OVERALL PICK

Kirk Cousins

MENTOR QB

Unprecedented

REDSHIRT HEISMAN MODEL

◆ FRONT OFFICE & LEADERSHIP

- ◆ **Unprecedented quarterback strategy.** Las Vegas drafted Heisman winner **Fernando Mendoza #1 overall** with the express plan to have him **sit behind Kirk Cousins** in a redshirt-rookie model designed to develop rather than rush the prospect.
- ◆ **Kubiak brings championship pedigree.** Hired Super Bowl offensive coordinator **Klint Kubiak** (ex-Denver OC) as head coach, signaling ambition to build a contender with veteran leadership and experienced coaching.
- ◆ **Aggressive free agency.** The Raiders spent **over \$280M** in free agency, building a veteran roster with the intention of competing immediately while Mendoza develops.
- ◆ **The bet: patience with a prize.** Most teams can't afford to sit a #1 pick; Las Vegas is betting that developing Mendoza slowly creates a generational advantage when he takes over.

◆ TRADES & MAJOR TRANSACTIONS

- ◆ **SIGNED** **Kirk Cousins, QB** — **\$20M/1yr guaranteed**, brought in as both starting QB and mentor to Ferdinand Mendoza in an unprecedented arrangement.
- ◆ **DRAFTED** **Fernando Mendoza, QB #1 overall** — Heisman winner, **41 TDs, 6 INTs, 72% completion, 3,535 yards, National Champion, Consensus All-American** — sitting Year 1.
- ◆ **SIGNED** **Tyler Linderbaum, C** — **highest-paid center in football**, anchoring the offensive line for Kirk Cousins' operation.
- ◆ **SIGNED** **LBs Nakobe Dean and Quay Walker** — elite defensive additions to complement a veteran pass rush and coverage group.
- ◆ **COACHING STAFF OVERHAUL** **Kubiak** brings a proven Super Bowl offensive system to the franchise, creating continuity for Cousins and Mendoza.

◆ PLAYER UPDATES & CAMP BATTLES

- ◆ **Kirk Cousins, QB.** Playing mentor to the future franchise QB while leading a veteran roster in 2026. His on-field teaching and locker-room presence will directly impact Mendoza's development.
- ◆ **Fernando Mendoza, QB (sitting Year 1).** The Heisman winner is in a unique situation: learn the pro game, study Cousins, develop timing with receivers, and take over a veteran-ready roster in 2027 — not immediately thrust into starting before he's ready.
- ◆ **Tyler Linderbaum, C.** The highest-paid center in football, tasked with stabilizing the line for both Cousins and the eventual Mendoza transition.
- ◆ **Nakobe Dean & Quay Walker, LBs.** Elite defensive acquisitions adding immediate impact to a unit being built around veteran leadership.
- ◆ **The offensive philosophy.** Klint Kubiak's Super Bowl system arrives intact; Cousins knows it, and Mendoza will learn it during Year 1 of sitdown.

◆ LATEST ROSTER MOVES

MOVE	DETAIL
▲ Kirk Cousins, QB	Starting QB, 1 yr / \$20M guaranteed
▲ Fernando Mendoza, QB	No. 1 overall, redshirt year
▲ Tyler Linderbaum, C	Highest-paid center, OL anchor
▲ Nakobe Dean, LB	Elite defensive acquisition
▲ Quay Walker, LB	Defensive investment
▲ Klint Kubiak, HC	Super Bowl OC hired as coach
▲ Veteran roster build	280M+ free agency spend

◆ THE BOTTOM LINE

Las Vegas has implemented an unprecedented strategy: draft a Heisman winner #1 overall, sit him for a year, and develop him behind a Super Bowl offensive coordinator and veteran quarterback. Fernando Mendoza's credentials are impeccable (41 TDs, 6 INTs, National Champion), but the redshirt approach risks losing a year of elite rookie receiver production and salary cap flexibility. **If Mendoza truly thrives after a year of patient development, Las Vegas will have built something generational.** If the strategy doesn't work, questions about the #1 overall decision will linger. For now, Kirk Cousins runs the offense, Klint Kubiak's system gets implemented, and Mendoza watches from the sideline — a camp storyline unlike any other in football.